

Australia Chair Daily Brief

AUSTRALIA · NEW ZEALAND · THE PACIFIC ISLANDS

Saturday, September 5, 2026

RE: PIF closes with China missile statement, Nauru dissents · One Nation topples Labor in WA by-election · ADF sexual violence inquiry named · Kiribati calls Forum snub 'disappointing' · France boosts New Caledonia funding

ASX 200 **9,006** -0.95% AUD/USD **0.7205** +0.59% NZX 50 **13,974** +1.50% NZD/USD **0.5882** -0.64%

BRENT **96.28** +6.40%

TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Concluded the 55th Pacific Islands Forum in Koror with a joint statement calling for 24 hours' advance notice of ballistic missile tests, with Nauru the sole formal dissenter.
- 2 Lost the safe Western Australian seat of Secret Harbour to One Nation on a 19 percent swing, with Labor shedding 23 percent of its primary vote in a seat vacated by veteran minister Paul Papalia.
- 3 Appointed former senator Natasha Stott Despoja to lead a one-year independent inquiry into sexual violence within the Australian Defence Force, with public hearings from next year and ADF non-disclosure agreements set aside.

TOP STORIES

CHINA-PACIFIC

Pacific Islands Forum closes with joint statement on China's missile test, Nauru alone dissents

On September 4, the final day of the 55th Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting in Koror, Palau, incoming chair Surangel Whipps Jr read a joint statement agreed by every member except Nauru, which "formally dissented." The statement calls on all states conducting intercontinental ballistic missile tests to provide advance notification "at least 24 hours in accordance with international practice," addressing China's July test that passed over several island nations. Beijing's foreign ministry said China is "willing to work with South Pacific countries" to safeguard regional peace.

So what: The 24-hour notification benchmark is now the standard Canberra, Wellington and Washington will invoke against any further Chinese test near Pacific waters.

Pattern: Pacific foreign ministers meeting on August 25 broke up without a joint statement on the same missile test; the leaders' text on September 4 carried over Nauru's dissent.

per Samoa Observer: "Concerns over China's missile test at P.I.F." · also RNZ

AU-POLITICS

One Nation takes safe Labor seat of Secret Harbour in Western Australia

One Nation's Luke Herdegen won the West Australian state seat of Secret Harbour, vacated by veteran Labor minister Paul Papalia, with Labor shedding 23 percent of its primary vote on a 19 percent swing. The ABC reported that internal Labor polling in the weeks before Papalia's resignation already showed One Nation on track to win. Notre Dame University politics professor Martin Drum said voters were frustrated with "the cost of living, housing pressures and their future prospects."

So what: The result hands One Nation its first breach of Labor's Western Australian heartland after a decade of state dominance and sets the terms of the party's federal positioning.

per ABC News: "How One Nation snatched the safe Labor seat of Secret Harbour" · also The Australian

AU-DEFENSE

Stott Despoja to lead independent inquiry into ADF sexual violence

Former senator Natasha Stott Despoja will lead a one-year inquiry into sexual violence within the Australian Defence Force, a key recommendation of the Royal Commission into Defence and Veteran Suicide, which found sexual misconduct was a "systemic issue" in the ADF. The inquiry covers prevention, reporting, and the ADF's response to the royal commission. Public hearings begin next year, and non-disclosure agreements struck between the ADF and victim-survivors will not be enforced for the inquiry's purposes.

So what: The non-disclosure waiver determines how much evidence reaches the public record before the inquiry reports in 2027.

per ABC News: "Former senator to take 'independent' look at sexual violence in the ADF"

OVERNIGHT

PACIFIC-POLITICS · 1NEWS

Kiribati calls PIF closing snub 'disappointing'

Kiribati said it was overlooked during closing proceedings at the 55th Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting in Koror, describing the episode as "disappointing," 1News reported. The friction follows the week's dispute over the Forum's response to China's missile test, in which Kiribati was among the states resisting stronger language.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY · THE SATURDAY PAPER

Five leaders absent from Palau summit as Australia's treaty run reaches Fiji

The Saturday Paper counts five key nations pulling out of the Palau leaders meeting and sets it against Australia's run of security agreements: Tuvalu in 2023, Naoero in 2024, Papua New Guinea in 2025, and Vanuatu and Fiji both in 2026. The PNG treaty, it reports, was driven almost entirely by the Pacific side and "rankled most in Beijing," with a Chinese diplomat asking whether PNG still "wanted to be friends."

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY · ABC PACIFIC

Albanese's \$600 million Pacific drug package promises surveillance and policing

Prime Minister Anthony Albanese announced \$600 million at the Palau leaders meeting to combat drug trafficking, funding increased aerial surveillance across the Pacific, improved maritime capability, and additional police training and support. The ABC reported leaders backed the Waqa Moana initiative to halt drug smuggling with that Australian support, against a backdrop of escalating crime and HIV transmission in Fiji.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY · PNG POST-COURIER

Exercise Pukpuk restores facilities at PNG's Igam Barracks

Four decrepit structures at Igam Barracks in Lae have been refurbished to modern standards through Exercise Pukpuk, a multilateral defence exercise, the Post-Courier reported. The works form the community infrastructure component of the exercise, which brings a multinational force into Papua New Guinea's Morobe province.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Hastie warns Chinese AI poses high risk

Liberal MP Andrew Hastie warned that Chinese artificial intelligence systems present a high risk, The Australian reported. The intervention lands the same week the paper reported taxpayer funding for an academic who collaborated with People's Liberation Army scientists, and follows the Australian Research Council's tightening of foreign interference rules.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Trans-Tasman police operation nets man over threats to Australian MPs' offices

New Zealand police arrested a 42-year-old Australian national in Auckland on June 26 after the Australian Federal Police flagged threatening calls to electorate offices in New South Wales, Queensland and Tasmania. Acting Senior Sergeant Craig Burrow said the calls were "offensive and threatening." He was convicted in the Auckland District Court on August 19, then rearrested at Sydney Airport and refused bail.

PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · FBC NEWS (FIJI)

Fiji committee questions data sovereignty under Australia treaties

Fiji's Standing Committee on Foreign Affairs and Defence heard submissions questioning whether citizens' privacy and data rights are protected under the proposed Fiji-Australia Vuvale Union and Ocean of Peace Alliance treaties. Member Virendra Lal asked whether Fiji's national communication networks would become "entirely dependent on Australian technology." Permanent Secretary for Policing Berenado Daveta said Fiji will protect its sovereignty.

NEW CALEDONIA · RNZ NATIONAL

France commits more financial help to New Caledonia

French Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu announced additional financial assistance for New Caledonia, RNZ reported. The amount and its allocation were not detailed in initial reporting.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu suspends SHEFA province secretary-general and deputy

The Public Service Commission has suspended SHEFA Provincial Government Council Secretary-General Lionel Kaluat and Assistant Secretary-General Liah John Kalpoi, PSC Chairman Meta Nganga confirmed. A source told the Daily Post the SG's suspension relates to alleged misappropriation of about VT8 million; the assistant was suspended over alleged unauthorised travel. Michelle Jonas Trief is acting SG.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu's VT192 million electricity fuel subsidy exhausted

The Utilities Regulatory Authority said the government's VT192 million electricity fuel subsidy, disbursed from June to September through UNELCO Engie, VUI Ltd and VANPAWA, is fully spent. Fuel price movements will now feed directly into tariff adjustments rather than being cushioned by the Ministry of Finance and Economic Management support.

FIJI · FBC NEWS (FIJI)

Fiji deputy PM ties climate damage to health infrastructure risk

Deputy Prime Minister Manoa Kamikamica, opening the 2026 Pacific Islands Health Research Symposium at Fiji National University, said damage to facilities, saltwater intrusion and shifting vector-borne disease patterns make climate change a direct threat to public health and the economy. "The distance between a sound piece of research and a policy change is rarely a scientific difference. It is usually a translation problem," he said.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Kalsakau objects to expatriate appointment at Airports Vanuatu

Opposition Leader Ishmael Kalsakau said qualified Ni-Vanuatu citizens could run Airports Vanuatu Limited, after the board appointed Shalendra Maharaj as chief executive on a five-year term. Chairman Jesse Benjamin said the recruitment was "thorough, transparent and highly competitive." Maharaj has worked with Emirates, Fiji Airways, Qantas Airways and dnata, and manages airports in Western Australia.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Port Moresby police base attacked after alleged police shooting

The NCD Taskforce 10 police base at Koki was nearly destroyed after unknown suspects allegedly attempted to burn it down following the death of a youth in an alleged police shooting, the Post-Courier reported. Police said they will investigate the shooting.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Wabag bishop urges peace ahead of PNG's 2027 elections

Wabag Catholic Diocese Bishop Justin Ain Soongie, patron of Caritas Enga, called on people in Enga Province to promote peace and stay out of trouble ahead of Papua New Guinea's 2027 national general elections, saying the province should set a precedent for elections to come.

NEW ZEALAND

TRADE-ECONOMY · WSJ

Reserve Bank of New Zealand delivers further rate increase

The Reserve Bank of New Zealand raised its policy rate again, the Wall Street Journal reported, extending the tightening cycle it resumed earlier in the year. The NZX 50 closed at 13,974, up 1.50 percent, on September 4, while the New Zealand dollar traded at 0.5882 against the US dollar, down 0.64 percent.

NZ-POLITICS · BEEHIVE (NZ GOVT)

Government funds Pasifika youth skills programme

Youth Minister James Meager and Pacific Peoples Minister Paul Goldsmith announced \$125,000 for Pasifika Festivals Aotearoa to deliver the Pasifika Youth Producers Programme, matched dollar-for-dollar by Creative New Zealand. Meager said the programme reflects a focus on initiatives that deliver "measurable outcomes for young people."

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

PALAU · DIPLOMATIC · TAIPEI TIMES

Taiwan's foreign minister attacks China's 'wolf warrior' diplomacy at PIF

Taiwan's foreign minister criticised Beijing's conduct at the Pacific Islands Forum in Koror as "wolf warrior" diplomacy, the Taipei Times reported on its front page. Taiwan attended the 2026 leaders meeting after being excluded from the 2025 meeting in Solomon Islands.

REGIONAL · STATE MEDIA REACTION · GLOBAL TIMES

STATE MEDIA

Chinese expert says Pacific concerns should not be 'hijacked by geopolitical agenda'

Global Times quoted a Chinese expert saying regional concerns should not be "hijacked by geopolitical agenda" in commenting on the Forum's split over China's missile test. The framing places responsibility for the dispute on outside powers rather than on the test itself.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

ASIO chief says leaders ignored terror warnings before Bondi

The head of ASIO said political leaders disregarded his warnings about the terrorism threat environment before the Bondi attack, The Australian reported. The claim goes to the handling of threat advice at the political level rather than to the agency's assessments themselves.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

One Nation's online operation outpaced Labor's campaign

The Australian examined the social media tactics behind One Nation's by-election win, arguing Labor's campaign playbook was no match for the party's online reach. A companion piece reports One Nation voters are consolidating behind the party in a contest increasingly framed as Albanese's Labor against Hanson's One Nation.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Chinese portside property purchases escaped foreign investment checks

The Australian reported that sensitive Chinese purchases of land adjacent to Australian ports avoided Foreign Investment Review Board scrutiny. The ASX 200 closed at 9,006 on September 4, down 0.95 percent, with the Australian dollar at 0.7205, up 0.59 percent, and Brent at 96.28, up 6.40 percent.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · PUBLIC RADIO GUAM

Guam governor frames Forum membership as 'better control of our destiny'

Guam's governor described the benefits of full Pacific Islands Forum membership in terms of self-determination, Public Radio Guam reported, saying it would give the territory "better control of our destiny."

CALENDAR WATCH

expected in
September 2026

Fiji Constitutional Review Commission report to Cabinet

The report sets the terms of any move to amend Fiji's 2013 constitution.

7 Nov 2026

New Zealand general election, advance voting from 26 October

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues to set foreign and defence policy through the 2027 Forum New Zealand will host.

2027

Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting, Auckland

New Zealand's Troika membership and host role commit it to delivering on the priorities set in Koror.

next year 2026

Public hearings of the ADF sexual violence inquiry

Stott Despoja's one-year inquiry is the main vehicle for implementing the royal commission's sexual misconduct recommendation.

2027

Papua New Guinea national general elections

Church and provincial leaders are already campaigning on election-related violence in the Highlands.

ALSO TODAY

ABC NEWS

ABC: everyone but Australia is reconsidering its relationship with America

Laura Tingle's analysis notes that Deputy Prime Minister Richard Marles "put a different spin on what 'making real progress in relation to AUKUS' now means" this week, and argues Australian federal politics has avoided the debate other allies are having about US reliability.

ABC NEWS

Real net national disposable income fell 0.4 percent in the June quarter

The ABS measure of income per person after inflation shrank 0.4 percent in the June quarter, the ABC reported, describing it as a broader measure of prosperity than real GDP. Albanese linked the mood to One Nation's momentum; Paul Keating told a Sydney audience governments are "afraid of change."

SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Australian rescue team lands in Kathmandu as 36 Australians remain missing

A 15-strong specialist drone team, including 10 Fire and Rescue NSW personnel, arrived in Kathmandu after a plea for help from Nepal's government. The ABC reports six missing Australians were found safe this week, with 36 still unaccounted for, most near the Gyirong border crossing.

EAST-WEST CENTER

East-West Center and PIDP attend Palau leaders meeting

The East-West Center and the Pacific Islands Development Program joined Pacific leaders in Palau to strengthen regional partnerships, the Center announced.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

THE DIPLOMAT

Australia Should Work With China, Not Try to Contain It

The piece argues China's growing power is reshaping the region and that a containment posture is one Australia cannot hope to win militarily. It urges a diplomatic and economic response instead.

Argument: Australia should meet China's growing power with diplomacy and deeper economic ties rather than military confrontation.

So what: [Runs against the treaty-building strategy Australia has pursued in the Pacific since 2023.](#)

THE DIPLOMAT

Why Australian Politics Is Shifting Right, Not Left

The article attributes the growth of far-right politics in Australia to nationalism, authoritarian sentiment and populism rather than to conventional swing-voter economics.

Argument: Nationalism, authoritarianism and populism explain the rise of far-right politics in Australia.

So what: [Frames the One Nation by-election result as structural rather than a protest vote on cost of living.](#)

THE DIPLOMAT

Human Rights Are Essential to Australia's Interests

The piece argues governments such as Australia's should treat the defence of civil society and press freedom in the region as core interest rather than optional advocacy, and links it to a broader democratic resurgence.

Argument: Defending civil society and a free press across the region is central to Australia's interests, not a luxury.

So what: [Bears on the Rabuka and Marape-led Pacific mission on West Papua human rights announced this week.](#)